

NEW POSITION Punjab Congress president Pargat Singh (extreme right)

IANS

PUNJAB

FULLBACK IS THE FALLBACK

Pargat entered the field as a compromise state Congress chief, after months of factional war. But in politics as in hockey, he's forced to play defence

By **Anilesh S. Mahajan**

FOR A PARTY THAT SPENT THE SUMMER AT WAR with itself, the Punjab Congress had a neat start to October. Congratulations flowed to a new state chief—national hockey captain-turned-neta Pargat Singh—from all faction heads who were skipping each other's events till the other day. Even the man Pargat replaced, Amarinder Singh Raja Warring, teed off with textbook grace. But in Punjab, it was too good to last.

Upon handing in his papers to Rahul Gandhi in Delhi, Warring had said he was acting voluntarily. "No one asked me to resign—everyone has to become an ex someday." But then came a mildly sour afternote: "I am not sure, but perhaps Sachin Pilot felt Raja should be removed." Over days, the bile rose. At the ceremony to instal Pargat as chief, Warring said, "I only consider Rahul Gandhi my leader." That came with another dig at the new state-in-charge. "It is possible that Pilot *saab* may cut my ticket next time."

Soon, Warring was doing unto Pargat what others, especially former chief minister Charanjit Singh Channi, had been doing to him all year—skipping official dos, holding parallel huddles with loyalists on the same day. In short, after two exhausting rounds of central refereeing, first attempted by former Chhattisgarh CM Bhupesh Baghel and then Pilot, it was back to square one.

Warring's barbs express a duality that tugs at the heart of Congress politics here: Punjab's wishes and Delhi's *firman*. If anyone can discern either of through the burning stubble, that is. The local unit is in a state of permanent civil war: that has already cost the party leaders like Amarinder Singh, Ravneet Bittu and Sunil Jakhar. Of the stubble that's left, Channi, Sukhjinder Randhawa and Partap Bajwa are good at unity only against a common foe.

The central peacemakers, in turn, are battle-scarred but not necessarily victorious survivors of their own provincial battles. Their strike rate in Punjab is commensurately iffy; their turnover rate: high.

Baghel came in early 2025: he was to steer the ship till the 2027 election. But the heat on the farm got too